



More Gujarat districts get PUBG ban

After banning PUBG from Rajkot district, Bhavnagar and Gir Somnath have also reportedly implemented a ban on the gaming title. <https://digit.in/apr19-23>



Huawei plays it unfair

Huawei has now tried passing off DSLR photos as smartphone shots three times. <https://digit.in/apr19-24>



Rotten Eggs

Easter eggs are fine, but an oversaturation of pop culture references in movies is just getting tiresome

Aditya Madanapalle | aditya@digit.in

Easter eggs are a mainstay of software where there is an inside joke or message hidden deep within a computer game or software. These are typically not easy to get to, and you may have to look up instructions to uncover one. Every version of Android has an Easter egg for example, which are pretty complex interactive environments now. Easter eggs are so much of a software thing, that there is not even a disambiguation page on Wikipedia to help you get to the origin of the term, which comes from the tradition of egg hunts during Easter. Now, over the years, Easter eggs have spread to videos as well... many episodes of Seinfeld for example, have a verbal or visual shout out to Superman. There is a "Pizza Planet Truck" in most Pixar movies.

Now, Easter Eggs are well hidden, and have zero impact on how you actu-

ally enjoy the movie. They are not in your face and obvious. Recent movies have immersion breaking pop culture references, which are shout outs to other fictional universes, or the real world. These are at times overt, and necessary for the story to progress. One movie which was stuffed with Easter eggs and pop culture references was Ready Player One. The movie blurred the line between what can be considered an Easter egg, and what can be considered a pop culture reference. The movie also had to go out of its way to explain video games, and the very concept of Easter eggs, to a mass audience. For someone steeped in video games and pop culture, the explanation is just unnecessary and boring. If you are actually aware of the sequence of events leading up to the videogame shown in the end, then the ending is just a disappointing anticlimax. On the other hand, those who are not aware of these pop culture references, or uncovered an Easter egg in a video game, will not understand what's going on despite an explanation.

In Ready Player One, when Wade Watts dresses up as Buckaroo Banzai, the movie did not have to point out the fact. In Avengers: Infinity War, there are a bunch of overt references to Alien. If you have not seen Star Wars:

The Empire Strikes Back, then there is an entire sequence in Civil War, where Spider-Man takes down Ant Man along with Iron Man and War Machine, which will not make any sense. Meet the Spartans for example, is stuffed with pop culture references and handles the situation well. The fact that it is a parody film helps, but the scenes are equally funny whether or not you get the references. It doesn't matter if you recognise the people getting Sparta kicked, the whole scene elicits laughter – which is the intended response at that point.

Many of these movies do have an additional layer of Easter eggs beneath the ones that they make obvious. The posters for Ready Player One for example, have a maze that leads up to an egg in the middle of the One. Infinity War has a bunch of references to the comic books, and Groot is seen playing Defender. These are well done, not in your face, and if you do not see them, you do not really lose out. Getting into the MCU is already problematic enough for people who have not been watching the movies, and have never consumed the comics. Add to that the complexity of having to watch a bunch of other movies, have played a bunch of video games that were never released in India, and even marketing campaigns that we might have never heard of (do you know who Grimace is?), and you have a situation where just an MCU movie can be intimidating. These western pop culture references are pervasive, and when every new movie is filled to the brim with them, then it just becomes increasingly difficult to figure out what is going on. Last year, Ready Player One, Deadpool 2, Ant Man and the Wasp, Ralph Breaks the Internet, Venom, Jurassic World: Fallen Kingdom and Solo were all filled with just too many pop culture references, in-universe jokes and Easter eggs. After a point, it becomes fatiguing for the audience. You start missing the times when you could just go and watch a movie for what it is, not having to worry about your prior media consumption history. **R**